

Psalm 79

From Ruin to Restored Praise

O God, the heathen are come into thine inheritance
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O God, the heathen are come into thine inheritance; thy holy temple have they defiled; they have laid Jerusalem on heaps.
- 2 The dead bodies of thy servants have they given to be meat unto the fowls of the heaven, the flesh of thy saints unto the beasts of the earth.
- 3 Their blood have they shed like water round about Jerusalem; and there was none to bury them.
- 4 We are become a reproach to our neighbours, a scorn and derision to them that are round about us.
- 5 How long, LORD? wilt thou be angry for ever? shall thy jealousy burn like fire?
- 6 Pour out thy wrath upon the heathen that have not known thee, and upon the kingdoms that have not called upon thy name.
- 7 For they have devoured Jacob, and laid waste his dwelling place.
- 8 O remember not against us former iniquities: let thy tender mercies speedily prevent us: for we are brought very low.
- 9 Help us, O God of our salvation, for the glory of thy name: and deliver us, and purge away our sins, for thy name's sake.
- 10 Wherefore should the heathen say, Where is their God? let him be known among the heathen in our sight by the revenging of the blood of thy servants which is shed.
- 11 Let the sighing of the prisoner come before thee; according to the greatness of thy power preserve thou those that are appointed to die;
- 12 And render unto our neighbours sevenfold into their bosom their reproach, wherewith they have reproached thee, O Lord.
- 13 So we thy people and sheep of thy pasture will give thee thanks for ever: we will shew forth thy praise to all generations.

2 · CONTEXT

A communal lament over the devastation of Jerusalem and its temple, likely composed in the aftermath of an invasion that left the city in ruins and its dead unburied. Unlike Psalm 74's focus on the desecrated sanctuary, Psalm 79 centers on the human cost—slaughter, reproach among the nations, and the unbearable question of how long this will continue. Henry notes its movement from raw grief through urgent petition to a vow of perpetual thanksgiving, trusting that the very people now scattered will again be called God's own flock.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The devastation is named specifically: the temple defiled, Jerusalem reduced to rubble, the bodies of God's servants left as food for beasts, blood poured out with no one left to bury the dead. The final indignity is social—Jerusalem has become a reproach and mockery to surrounding nations.

Verse 5-9

The lament turns to petition: how long will God's anger burn like fire? Rather than asking only for relief, the psalmist asks God to pour out wrath instead on the nations that do not know Him, and pleads for mercy that does not dwell on 'former iniquities'—an honest admission that the nation's own sin contributed to this judgment, alongside a plea for God's help 'for the glory of thy name' rather than on the basis of merit.

Verse 10-13

The psalm's final concern is God's own reputation: why should the nations get to ask 'where is their God?' The plea for vindication is bound up with concern for the prisoner's sighing and those appointed to die, asking that reproach be repaid to the neighboring nations. The psalm closes not in despair but in a vow: God's people, His flock, will give thanks forever and declare His praise to all generations—hope surviving the ruins.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

National catastrophe and personal grief over unburied dead and desecrated worship are met in this psalm with unfiltered lament rather than false composure, yet the lament is aimed at God rather than away from Him. Even amid ruin, the psalmist's deepest

concern is God's honor among the nations, and the psalm's final word is a vow of enduring praise—hope surviving even total devastation.

Application for life today.

When grief over loss or injustice feels too large for polite prayer, let this psalm's raw honesty give you permission to lament specifically and urgently rather than softening your words to God. Notice that the psalmist's ultimate appeal is to God's own name and glory, not merely his own relief—consider praying that way when your own situation feels unresolved. Practice ending hard prayers, as this psalm does, with a forward-looking vow of praise rather than only present complaint.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What loss or injustice in your life or community needs the kind of specific, unfiltered lament this psalm models rather than a quickly composed response?

2. How does appealing to God's own reputation and 'name's sake' (vv. 9–10), rather than only your own need, change the way you pray about a hard situation?

3. What would it look like to end a season of grief, as this psalm does, with a genuine vow of ongoing praise (v. 13)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).